

consider the myriad policies and schemes of the central and state governments. In workshops in which Mittal Institute researchers participated with colleagues at the All India Disaster Mitigation Institute, it became clear that particular problems of adaptation to heat could be addressed by pre-existing central and state government schemes, even though the latter were not always thought of in the context of heat. That's useful information for someone looking for resources to get a heat adaptation plan up and running.

Experimentation: With awareness and information, at least some of the preconditions exist for rampant experimentation to ensue. Why do I focus on experimenting? Because none of us remotely have all the answers. With wet bulb temperatures scaling new and scary heights, and persisting longer, we are in uncharted waters. Here, I'll confine myself to point to a couple of experiments that I already see running in India or elsewhere that seem to me to be

worth enhancing and emulating.

Cities all over the world are appointing so-called Chief Heat Officers (nurtured by the Rockefeller Foundation spurred Chief Resilience Officers). These are individuals who report to a mayor or city council whose sole responsibility is preparing the city to deal not just with acute heat emergencies, but with ambient rise in temperatures. It requires short-term and longer term actions, along with all the diplomacy and politicking that goes with claiming resources to invest in public goods. It's early days. The CROs had mixed results, but then that's the nature of an experiment. As the work of Janaagraha in Bengaluru has taught us now, our city level governance frameworks are not the most robust, so crafting appropriate accountability mechanisms onto India's Heat Action Plans will likely take some work.

Given the somewhat unpredictable nature of all manner of climate disasters, society has to create a capability to respond quickly. In some instances, India has made

remarkable strides. Cyclone warnings on the southeastern seaboard for instance have saved thousands of lives relative to a decade ago. But sometimes disasters strike much faster, including heat waves. Crisis Ready is one global non-profit that has worked in India, including helping figure out Covid response times, on many an occasion, as it has with California wildfires, floods in various places, and so on. That very-quick-response capability, digitally harnessing lots of local resources, is one we must nurture. Recently, the next-gen robotics and AI institute ARTPARK, at the Indian Institute of Science, has released software that helps model rapid response capability that will help with predicting heat wave incidence, as well as how disease patterns—for instance, dengue—will change as proximate heat patterns change.

Of course, experiments are easier to conceive on pre-existing platforms and, if successful, easier to scale. Large corporations can use their reach to catalyse such experiments, as can industry representative bodies. IndiaStack is a remarkable piece of digital infrastructure whose mapping to responding to climate change is already starting to be apparent.

India is vulnerable to the enormous challenge of extreme heat and yet unprepared. However, various initiatives and efforts provide a glimpse of what is possible when collaboration and ingenuity come together. We have to internalise that heat is not a disaster of the future—it is a crisis of the present. The year 2024 was the hottest on record, but it was only the hottest year *so far*. **BT**

Views are personal



THOSE RELUCTANT TO FUND ADAPTATION WORRY THAT DOING SO WILL REDUCE THE URGENCY TO MITIGATE CLIMATE CHANGE